

The advent of online trading in the information age allowed Daniel to buy and sell stocks on his own without ever leaving home. He didn't worry that he did not have a professional financial advisor to guide him. Besides, his day trading firm's premise was that "educated investors don't need brokers." Daniel enjoyed the challenge. He was also drawn to the familiar excitement and anticipation that his gambling days had first allowed him to experience.

As soon as the New York Stock Exchange opened, he placed his first bet, hoping that the shares of stock would go up in value by the end of the day. Daniel's profits in day trading depended solely on the small movements in stock prices before he cashed out at the end of the day. If the stock went up, he made money. If it went down, he lost.

His first attempt earned him several thousand dollars and Daniel excitedly started daydreaming about not going back to his regular day job even after he recovered. Subsequent trades were just as profitable and Daniel quit his job. At first, his wife Penny was happy to have him at home since he had always worked long hours and she rarely saw him. In time, his trading became addictive, and Penny again rarely saw him. Once trading consumed him, he ignored Penny. Daniel would lock himself in his office and spend his time trading or thinking about trading. On the rare occasions that Daniel would leave his office, he would be glued to the financial shows on television.

Emboldened by his winnings, Daniel started placing larger trades more frequently. Typically he would exceed hundreds of online trades a day, getting in and out of various stocks and usually ending the day by selling all of the shares. Unfortunately, his streak did not last.

Daniel started moving through the traditional phases in the addiction process. The first stage was a winning phase, where he was winning more often than losing. Excitement predominated

